



Thrillseeker Vacations

Feel like getting out of your cage? Have a lot of money? Here are some spots to take your daredevil nature: <http://dgit.in/thrillvacs>

Prison Break

Think you can bust out of prison? Here's an article telling you exactly what's at risk during a prison break: <http://dgit.in/pbreak1>

back, "You know, considering you wrote the story behind the game, I'd expect you to be a little more active."
"Tad'moh, lod'ni. You're wayyy too tense." He stretched a little more, his ease, making Godric uneasy, in turn. The nervous game maker let out another curse under his breath and continued with his pacing.

I wasn't confident enough. I should've been more prepared.

The great doors opened and the Prefect – the Praetor's aide – walked out. He looked around and saw Godric and Cain. He walked up to them. "I'm sorry to keep you waiting."

"That's fine, engard."

"I'm sorry, boy. The Praetor wasn't very impressed with the focus group results."

He saw the look on Godric's face, and added, "It's not that the idea wasn't impressive. Your characters are really very life-like. But realism isn't enough for a game to be a success."

Cain spoke up. "Was it the story?"

"No, not at all. In fact, they found the story rather enthralling."

Cain beamed. Godric refrained the urge to punch him in the face.

"I'm sorry, Godric. Why don't you try something more... traditional?"

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"Traditional. Gah!"

Godric had spent the last plasm raving about what he thought about the Gaming Commision. Celeste sat on his couch, waiting for him to finish.

"And Cain? That shlok'ahk could use a few slaps himself."

"Hey! Mind your language."

"Sorry."

"Don't say it unless you mean it. And you know it wasn't Cain's fault. His writing was amazing."

"I know, I know. I'm just venting."

Celeste laughed. "Yes, I noticed. But you should take his advice and calm down, just a little."

Godric kept fuming, but he did mellow out a little.

"Good. Now – when I hit a wall, I generally take a step back and look at what I'm doing. That's generally how I find out what I did wrong. Or what I can do better. Think you can handle that?"

"Maybe."

"Come on, Godric. Give it a try."

So he tried. "Okay, I had a full-fledged game. The story obviously wasn't the problem. The pragmatizer made my characters look exceptionally life-like, and with my Harte engine, they were open-ended and extremely realistic and interactive."

"Were they?"

"Of course they were. They never reacted in a predictable way. No two conversations in the game are the same. The characters react to the gamer's own statements and actions accordingly."

"True, but does that make them anything like real people?"

"Close enough! I should know, I've spent quarks perfecting their interactive algorithms!"

"What makes us different from computer programs?"

Godric was a little taken aback by the sudden question. "What do you mean?"

"We could try making programs more and more realistic, we could try making them more in our image, to invoke a sense of realism in the inanimate. But they will always be missing something – something that sets the creator apart from the creation. What is it that makes us different?"

Godric began to think. What is she aiming at? "Well... several things, actually. But if I had to pick one, I'd say it would be our ability to make choices based on what we feel and think. To gauge a situation based on experience and feeling, rather than cold hard facts."

"Free will."

"Yes, free will."

"Then there's the answer to your question. You want to make the next big game? Show people a game that they're not entirely in control of. Let the program think for itself. Make its own decisions. Thrive, live, exist in its own little bubble of a code. Let the program believe that it is the centre of its universe."

"But where's the game in that?"

"The game's free will is an illusion. Even though it can make decisions on its own, exist on its own, players shall be the ones calling the shots, controlling the different aspects of the program. Winning depends on the ultimate outcome of the game. Either the gamers will do a great job, and the program shall exist 'til the end of time, or they will get negligent, and the program will crash of its own accord. Either way – this program will change the way we see gaming. Completely."

Godric was dumbstruck. "That's... brilliant."

"I have my moments."

"But it won't work."

"Why?"

"Free will is great, but it ties-in with self-awareness. What would happen if the program started questioning its very existence?"

"Hmm." It was Celeste's turn to look thoughtful. "I didn't think of that," she admitted.

